

Topic 4: Sport psychology

Overview

Students will have an understanding of the role that sports psychology has in facilitating optimal sporting performance of an individual athlete, sports teams and individuals in the teams. Students will understand the different psychological views, theories and perspectives, as indicated in the specification, and be able to apply this understanding by way of explanation to behaviours that ultimately affect sporting performance. Central to this topic will be the ongoing debate offering explanations between either nature or nurture or the interaction of both.

Students will look at the theories and then apply the different interpretation of each to the different situations and scenarios identified. They will be able to demonstrate both support for, and challenge to, a given theory or perspective and provide sporting examples to support this view.

Content

Subject content	What students need to learn
4.1 Factors that can influence an individual in physical activities	4.1.1 Knowledge and understanding of different personality theories and their application to different sporting situations. Personality theories Trait (Innate) theory – introvert/extrovert, neurotic/stable (Eysenck, Cattell's 16 Personality Factors) Interactionist theory Behaviour = function (personality, environment) Hollander's and Martens personality structure.
	4.1.2 Wood's Triadic Model: ideas/cognitions, emotions/effects and actions/behaviour. Understanding how attitudes are formed and shape behaviour. Changing attitudes: negative to positive – create 'cognitive dissonance' – Festinger.
	4.1.3 Arousal and its effect on performance. Positive/negative effects, under-/over-arousal, introverts/extroverts. Arousal and achieving optimal levels for performance – task differences, e.g. simple/gross skills, situational factors, stage of learning and personalities – Inverted-U hypothesis, Hull's Drive Theory. Catastrophe Theory.

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	4.1.4 Anxiety and its effect on performance. The three dimensions of anxiety: cognitive, somatic and behavioural. Types of anxiety, state and trait anxiety. The effects of anxiety of performance: over arousal, choking and catastrophe theory. Relationship between arousal and anxiety. Stress and stressors leading to anxiety – physiological, psychological, behavioural symptoms. Cognitive/Somatic strategies: mental practice/rehearsal, use of visualisation and imagery, 'self talk', pre-game routines, relaxation techniques, centring, thought stopping, PMR (Progressive Muscle Relaxation). 4.1.5 Aggression v. Assertion Knowledge and understanding, in relation to the player, coach and spectator, of aggression and assertion and the difference between the two. Theories Instinct (Lorenz), Social Learning (Bandura), Aggressive-Cue Hypotheses (Berkowitz) and Frustration-Aggression Hypothesis (Dollard). Types of aggression: hostile, channelled, reactive and instrumental. Causes of aggression, e.g. over-arousal, under developed moral reasoning, bracketed morality, and application to specific sporting situations. Strategies to reduce aggression/aggressive play. 4.1.6 Knowledge and understanding of motivation Types of motivation – self-motivation characteristics, positive, negative, intrinsic and extrinsic; link to rewards – internal/external, tangible/intangible. Theories of motivation Achievement Motivation Theory (Atkinson and McClelland). NAF (Need to Avoid Failure) and NACH (Need to Achieve). Characteristics of each and how they may be reflected in the same individual but in different circumstances and/or times. An application of these theories to optimise performance. Factors that influence behaviour: situation, personality, motivation and expectation. Use of goal setting to develop and enhance motivation.

Subject content	What students need to learn
	4.1.7 Definition, knowledge and understanding of social facilitation, including social inhibition. The positive and negative effects on a performer. The role of and effect of 'others' – passive (audience/co-actors) – interactive others (competitors/spectators). The effects of social facilitation on a novice to a highly skilled performer, the dominant response and the link to arousal (Drive theory and Inverted-U). Causes of and the and effects of Evaluation Apprehension (Zajonc and Cottrell). External influences, e.g. significant others, homefield advantage, distraction effect, proximity effect, and their impact on performance. Strategies to combat social inhibition.